

court decide the merits of the dispute or of particular issues.” *Warth v. Seldin*, *supra*, at 498. Standing doctrine embraces several judicially self-imposed limits on the exercise of federal jurisdiction, such as the general prohibition on a litigant’s raising another person’s legal rights, the rule barring adjudication of generalized grievances more appropriately addressed in the representative branches, and the requirement that a plaintiff’s complaint fall within the zone of interests protected by the law invoked. See *Valley Forge*, *supra*, at 474–475. The requirement of standing, however, has a core component derived directly from the Constitution. A plaintiff must allege personal injury fairly traceable to the defendant’s allegedly unlawful conduct and likely to be redressed by the requested relief. 454 U. S., at 472.

Like the prudential component, the constitutional component of standing doctrine incorporates concepts concededly not susceptible of precise definition. The injury alleged must be, for example, “distinct and palpable,” *Gladstone, Realtors v. Village of Bellwood*, 441 U. S. 91, 100 (1979) (quoting *Warth v. Seldin*, *supra*, at 501), and not “abstract” or “conjectural” or “hypothetical,” *Los Angeles v. Lyons*, 461 U. S. 95, 101–102 (1983); *O’Shea v. Littleton*, 414 U. S. 488, 494 (1974). The injury must be “fairly” traceable to the challenged action, and relief from the injury must be “likely” to follow from a favorable decision. See *Simon v. Eastern Kentucky Welfare Rights Org.*, 426 U. S., at 38, 41. These terms cannot be defined so as to make application of the constitutional standing requirement a mechanical exercise.

The absence of precise definitions, however, as this Court’s extensive body of case law on standing illustrates, see generally *Valley Forge*, *supra*, at 471–476, hardly leaves courts at sea in applying the law of standing. Like most legal notions, the standing concepts have gained considerable definition from developing case law. In many cases the standing question can be answered chiefly by comparing the allegations of the particular complaint to those made in prior standing